



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 16

INDIANA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Indiana's family courts and child-welfare system.

83

INDIANA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 126
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 22 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
MAY 14, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
40 OF 92

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

INDIANA AT A GLANCE.

Across 83 Indiana families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 126 82 of 83 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$56,250 median across 35 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 22 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 44.6% 32.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 83	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 82 of 83	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 40

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Indiana families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF INDIANA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	59	\$10,000	\$31,986	\$1,887,200
Lost Wages	42	\$5,000	\$59,188	\$2,485,901
Other Court Fees	27	\$400	\$2,404	\$64,900
Therapy / Evaluations	31	\$2,000	\$17,716	\$549,200
Reunification Services	26	\$50	\$10,500	\$273,000
GAL Fees	37	\$500	\$9,908	\$366,600
Asset Loss	38	\$21,000	\$94,166	\$3,578,300
Median Family Burden (35 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$56,250	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		22	1.8 yrs
Mean months lost		33	2.8 yrs
Total across all families		2,062	171.8 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · INDIANA

Most families documenting in Indiana are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		34	41%
Case closed: within last 2 years		22	27%
Not provided		12	14%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		6	7%
Active case: progress being made		4	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		40	48%
Family Court Only		28	34%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		11	13%
Unknown		3	4%
Family Court		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		19	23%
5 – 10 years		16	19%
3 – 5 years		14	17%
6 months – 1 year		14	17%
Less than 6 months		8	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		24	29%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		19	23%
50/50 Joint		12	14%
Full Custody		10	12%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		9	11%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Marion		10	12%
Allen		5	6%
Elkhart		3	4%
Porter		3	4%
Vanderburgh		3	4%
Fulton		2	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		27	33%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		16	19%
High Conflict Divorce		12	14%
Other: (Short answer)		9	11%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)		5	6%

04 PARENT VOICES — INDIANA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Indiana comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



It's terrified my children ripped my marriage apart, made us scared that if we don't immediately take our kids to the doctor with every bump and fall and scrape that they will come back and try to remove gave us fear of our own local public. Servants has caused our children [...]

— DEVIN

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The system has put my children in the hands of the abuser. The judge completely ignored the evidence.

— INDIANA PARENT · MICHELLE

MORE VOICES FROM INDIANA

Procedural failures and biased reporting—especially in documentation—led to a narrative that misrepresented me and negatively impacted my family. Instead of protecting stability, the system introduced confusion, delay, and unnecessary harm. The process became more about [...]

— EVA

It's destroyed me and my children and the bond we had

— JAMIE

Trauma PTSD due to removal all 5 children and my self major depression and my 5 year old is a self harmer. They destroyed a beautiful family left us in ruins.

— NICHOLE

The heartache sometimes is unbearable I had five kids always something going on .to nothing but silence worst thing in the world I will ever go thru

— MAVEN

Destroyed it & then caused same harm on 2 of the kids they wanted to blame me for.

— AMY

It has destroyed is mentally, physically, emotionally, and it has taken away time we could have shared together.

— DEONDA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system destroyed my family. When parents need both parents they favored one! Sure I made a mistake but to pay for the mistake for years and years. Even after I did all classes that was asked of me. I went from primary custody parent to only 5 hours every Sunday. I went from [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Completely destroyed and tore my family apart. 3 kids all in 3 diff homes. All kids now dealing with mental health issues and separation issues

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed the relationships I've spent 16yrs building. I have been permanently injured/nearly killed and after 4yrs without contact 2 out of 4 people that I woke to still having here on earth don't call or even send a happy birthday message. I've spent everything [...]

— BILL

Through the CHINS process, DCS has not only disrupted our family but has inflicted lasting emotional, spiritual, and financial strain, challenging our rights as parents and our ability to nurture our children in a safe, loving, and faith-centered environment

— KARI

The info I provided is just the tip of the ice berg. There is so much more. We have been ripped apart as a family. Little sisters once close torn apart never to see each other again. We are traumatized. Depressed. No one cares. No one will listen. No one will help.

— CRYSTAL

DESTROYED IT, my son doesn't even respond to myself or his grandparents and any of my family

— CHRISTOPHER

Traumatized us. Let an abusive sadistic man maintain control.

— KIM

These people have tore my kids away from loving parents only to scuritize and defamate me and my wife

— BRANDON

Destroyed us caused alot of issues had to quit my job to homeschool my kids they were trying their hardest to take my kids from me for no reason

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They stole my 3 kids and lied about it. Adopted them out.

— RALPH

They kidnapped 3 of my granddaughters, traumatized them and adopted 2 of them out, and gave the baby back after a year and a half. The 6 year old does not understand why she got adopted but her baby sister got to come home. They ripped our family apart.

— JOYCE

Destroyed my family and our future. My son isn't the same . Ruined my credit my reputation tried to cost me my retirement even.

— KATRINA

Traumatized, isolated my child from family.

— CHASITY

destroyed us made us resent eachother and the system went into deep depression made us spiral downhill since hearing

— JENNIFER

System has allowed her to continue to profit and be rewarded for the bad behavior all my keeping our children away from me

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

it has completely destroyed me as a mother I have tried fighting, but I've been standing alone such a long time, but I'm weak. I do not want to give up on my son. It was not only that, but there was conflict of interest with the DCS worker and I was promising things to find the [...]

— KELLI

This system has destroyed my family. My relationship with my son is being harmed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Striped my children and myself of the love and bond with a sibling and son.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



After a long and abusive marriage of 12 years my ex wife leveled piles of false alligations against me which were never sustained as they never happened. At 7 years post divorce I am still being held below guidelines time with my children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

As the primary parent who raised the children the heaviness of grief it has caused to the children and myself is difficult to describe. The children did not deserve to be placed in the unsafe environment with a parent who signed off their rights.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined our family bond made father out to be a villain my daughters think we can't protect them and don't love them mother has disabilities and can't see her kids they are her entire world. Since I am the leader of the family they have told my girls I don't love them and can't [...]

— CHRIS

This system is failing to protect a little girl who simply does not have a voice. While simultaneously encouraging our abuser to sabotage a future before its even started. My daughter just turned 3 and a half.

— ISAAC

Ex used old therapy messages without disclosing to opposing counsel as evidence of substance abuse, but there weren't any. I took 2 90 day hair follicle tests to debunk his allegations, and the judge seemed to just ignore my proof. Daughter complained of her grandmother abusing [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Separated my children and caused them to have emotional issues

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Made things worse then what they were

— CASEY

Shattered completely. Girls fear punishment for association....even tho they grown. Dad is money supply.

— SHELBY

Indiana dcs has robbed my children of what could have been a happy, normal childhood and rendered us gagged, bound, helpless and alone. The only protection my children needed was from the Department of Child Services.

— EMILY

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Robbed us of our rely and memories. Broken out bond and ruined out emotional and mental health effects our future relationships.

— SUZI

The system stole my entire soul from me, my first baby, the little girl who made me a mom. And gave my abuser power through lies and manipulation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has changed me on a molecular level, I am sicker now than I ever have been and I'm watching my children misunderstood why their mother isn't present like she was.

— KAYLE

Turned my kids against me.

— LIZA

Took away my rights as a mother time away from my son time spending with him cost me thousands asking the same thing over and over again.chose an abusive parent that now has custody.

— AMBER

The system showed me that the court system as a whole is extensively flawed. The system is a popularity contest of who knows who; not justice.

— MARRINA

It has alienated my sons from me. My rapist has custody of my children and withholds them from me whenever he wants. Its torn apart my family as I raised them on my own until 2021

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I've been harmed by a system where subjective interpretation carried more power than verified evidence. Where a mother's protective and caregiving choices were reframed in a way to steal my child from me.

— ALYSSA

They killed my son. They took my happiness. I feel like I walk eggshells every day and make sure my two-year-old is safe. They took trust for me. They took things for me that I'll never get back. I'll never get to see my son. Hug him hold him put him on a school bus or because [...]

— MIRANDA

65 Indiana parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — INDIANA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Indiana families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

The system has put my children in the hands of the abuser. The judge completely ignored the evidence.

— MICHELLE

It's terrified my children ripped my marriage apart, made us scared that if we don't immediately take our kids to the doctor with every bump and fall and scrape that they will come back and try to remove gave us fear of our own local public. Servants has caused our children great mental trauma has shut down even with years of therapy is still not better.

— DEVIN

Procedural failures and biased reporting—especially in documentation—led to a narrative that misrepresented me and negatively impacted my family. Instead of protecting stability, the system introduced confusion, delay, and unnecessary harm. The process became more about compliance than fairness, with real-life impacts overlooked. The process is ongoing and escalating, deteriorating my relationship with my children. No due process, defamation of character, false allegations, frivolous motions filed statistically every 2 weeks for 5 years, stole my transportation during co-parenting counseling, lost job at post office, smear campaign, unilateral decisions, parental alienation, third party interference, falsifying documents, corrupt, corrupt, corrupt

— EVA

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— DEONDA

The system destroyed my family. When parents need both parents they favored one! Sure I made a mistake but to pay for the mistake for years and years. Even after I did all classes that was asked of me. I went from primary custody parent to only 5 hours every Sunday. I went from receiving 112 a week in support to paying \$800 a month in support. My ex abused the court orders. Gave me visits based on if he felt I deserved visits. I tried to inform the gal she ignored me. The gal only visited my ex home and spoke with ex witnesses. Never visited my home or spoke with my witnesses. She ignored that I completed all my courses. My attorney never spoke up in court when asked if I completed the courses.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed the relationships I've spent 16yrs building. I have been permanently injured/nearly killed and after 4yrs without contact 2 out of 4 people that I woke to still having here on earth don't call or even send a happy birthday message. I've spent everything I earned in 50 yrs and retirement trying to find someone that would simply read the black and white to no avail. Now to top it all after losing my fiancé, father, grandmother, and my only 2 daughters along with my ability to walk I'm going to be put in prison over child support when I have never been behind until the wreck where I was nearly killed. My children, reputation, everything I've bought and paid for has been stolen while in jail or sold to get out. My home will be the last thing I loose along with my freedom here in three weeks.

— BILL

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— KELLI

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— ISAAC

Ex used old therapy messages without disclosing to opposing counsel as evidence of substance abuse, but there weren't any. I took 2 90 day hair follicle tests to debunk his allegations, and the judge seemed to just ignore my proof. Daughter complained of her grandmother abusing her (she lives with the ex now), and I had filed with CPS. They unsubstantiated the allegation, even after a forensic interview where the child clearly stated what happened.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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They killed my son. They took my happiness. I feel like I walk eggshells every day and make sure my two-year-old is safe. They took trust for me. They took things for me that I'll never get back. I'll never get to see my son. Hug him hold him put him on a school bus or because they didn't listen all because they let everything slide through their fingers.

— MIRANDA

I just recently saw my kids for about an hour after not seeing them for three years. I have missed so much of their life due to all of the false allegations and this ongoing narrative that depicts me as a monster. So many other aspects of my life have been negatively affected. The damage the system has caused my family is beyond repairable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It has completely and utterly broken me, beyond a level I thought possible. And I am a godd*mn STRONG woman. It is actively ruining my children's lives, and that is unbearable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The judge even called me a deadbeat 10 years being divorced 9 years 50/50 until we switch judges and now I'm a deadbeat dad all due to lies and yes I've got the proof

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The Guardian ad Litem, Sybil Sharvelle, appears to have been brainwashed by the father and claimed the mother is psychologically abusing the child after the child disclosed sexual abuse by the father for the second time and a PO was issued by a preponderance of the evidence by one judge, then transferred to another judge who dropped the PO and the child was taken by the father who received sole custody.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Traumatized use and used my son as a test subject the cause mental harm stress and broke us. My son may only live 5 years with is conditions and they stole 6 months we will never get back

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ruined my family, deprived me of my rights and taught me that money talks more than the truth. It has taught me that under civil law there is no right to counsel as there is under criminal law.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It put me through mental and emotional hell.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have lost precious time with my child because of delays and negligence. Numerous hearings ignored for me and granted for ex wife that cost my relationship with my son unmeasurably.

— JEFF

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Taken so much precious time my kids lost with me that we can never get back. Scarred the kids in seeing that the courts truly did not care about their best interest and let us down over and over.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Inflicted nothing but harm, pain, and ensured future issues to be processed in the future. This system torn us apart for no known reason and continues to steal money from my family while boosting the growing three million the state makes from support.

— JIM

It is a well-documented systematic network of people profiting off perpetuating the endless nightmare of abuse from my ex-husband and aiding in the slow public murder of myself and family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Make me take parenting classes, sych. Test, on probation, threatening me with jail, take all my money. I have deep depression to the point of thinking about suicide

— ANTHONY

The family court system has allowed my ex to abuse me post-separation via expensive litigation, delaying necessary services for our son who is struggling and has ignored every piece of evidence brought into the court room. The system has failed my child.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Damaged me like I was never their mother and telling my kids i never loved them or cared for them after case ended and how they also said that in court about me but not the father's not caring or loving them only me. They harmed me and I've done nothing wrong, sure I needed help with Environment living but they refused to help while having the funding. I deserve my kids back and a lawsuit with all the things I was put through. They truly don't have any idea what they are doing. I know my kids will resent them for allowing my family to talk about me in a negative way because they know I know they are abusive and they hate me for it too but why have my kids if you don't like me? They are part of me regardless but they act like I was never the mother to them. I don't want my family having any access to them due to their behaviors towards me..My kids don't need to be around that type of behavior towards me. My family has no respect for me or any care about me or how I feel hence why I can't see my kids is because of their behaviors.

— ANGEL

I have lost immeasurable time and experiences with my boy, ultimately losing my identity. I have had to turn down jobs, career paths, dreams, emotional connections with so many people who don't understand what I have gone through.

— JEFF

Created diversion, chaos, and emotionally trashed my family, sat back and watched the diversion they created... And used it for their own financial gain.

— MICHAEL

They are not just putting a mother and child through trauma; they are shaking an entire family. As a grandmother, watching my grandchild's sense of safety, routine, and connection be disrupted during critical developmental periods, while feeling powerless to protect them has been heartbreaking. This system does not only impact parents, but it also impacts the generations standing behind them trying to hold a strong and loving Christ loving family together.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has damaged me and my family. My oldest son has been taken from us all. He has a younger brother who talks about him daily. Who wishes he could see his brother and wonders why it has happened. It's affected him in ways we can't help 😞.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

It has completely made distrust with the system, the law is scared of the word family law. Allen County is a County where people help the abuse. My son's dad was allowed to come after my daughters. Everyone keeps saying this doesn't involve them. But the hurt and loss of losing a sibling the most disgusting way. We have to watch wear we go or we get attacked from the abuser. My whole family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My son Alex is now 20 years old, the same age I was when I had him, and I haven't seen him since he was 12. When he finally got Facebook, we were able to start messaging back and forth to keep in touch a little bit, but he has a whole life that doesn't include me now. For all I know, he hates me. Or is mad at me at the very least. And as he should be. I promised to never stop fighting until I brought him home and where did we end up? I've become a stranger to him, just someone he used to know, a person of the past. And I don't know anything about him anymore either. I don't know who he is or what kind of person he's turned out to be. I don't know what matters to him, what drives him, what his vision for life is. I don't know what his purpose or passion is, what inspires him, what his dreams or life goals are. I don't know if he has a girlfriend, if he has a job, what his plans for the future are, what his favorite food is, what his hobbies are. He's my son and, because of my government, the *justice* system, we are complete strangers.

— LINDSEY

They've taken the only thing that I've ever done right away from me.. I was a good mom. I am still a good mom and I love him with all my heart and I would do anything for them and they have turned them against me meaning they totally cut me out of their life and they treat me as if I'm the enemy and I've done nothing to them. Nothing...

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

65 full approved Indiana comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Indiana report comes from Indiana respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Indiana — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 83 Indiana families reporting here are not the universe of Indiana families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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